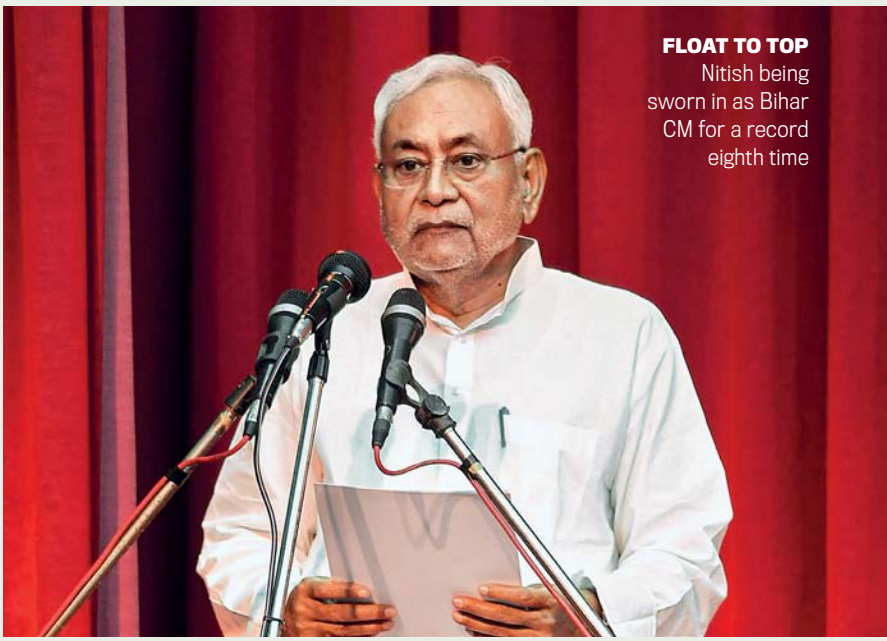
PERMANENT CM: 8 AND COUNTING



FLOAT TO TOP Nitish being sworn in as Bihar CM for a record eighth time

By August 10, Nitish Kumar, by now back at the helm of the grand coalition with the RJD-Congress-Left that he had walked out on in 2017, was throwing down the gauntlet to none other than Prime Minister Narendra Modi, his ally till two days ago. "He won in 2014; whether he will be able to continue after 2024 is something for him to assess," Nitish said at a brief interaction with the media. Even if he subsequently brushed aside a question on whether he himself would be a candidate for prime ministership, this was a rare bit of bravado for Nitish, known for his innate caution with words. But the math is easy to tot up. Bihar comes in only after Uttar Pradesh in terms of being a core heartland state—and its 40 Lok Sabha seats are the fourth highest bloc for any state, after UP's 80, only Maharashtra (48) and West Bengal (42) come above it. So the way it has turned colour puts some unexpected new verve into an otherwise comatose Opposition camp.

Bihar is also the state that inaugurated 'mahagathbandhan' politics in 2015, which was to offer one of the sternest challenges to the BJP in the Modi era. Realising that the only way to stop the BJP juggernaut was to pool together all anti-BJP votes rather than have them fragmented across parties, the JD(U) had mended fences with the RJD after two decades and pulled in the Congress. Result: the grand alliance set in motion some great synergy, winning a mammoth 178 seats out of the total 243. The mahagathbandhan model was to fray gradually, as it didn't work out as well elsewhere in India—but in Bihar, the reasons for the synergy still exist as the RJD and JD(U) command support from complementary social blocs and are, crucially, in unison on pending policies like a caste census. In short, even if Lok Sabha elections go differently from assembly patterns, the BJP has landed itself an unforeseen new threat in the run-up to 2024.

HAVING LINKED UP HIS EBC-MAHADALIT VOTE TO THE RJD'S MUSLIM-YADAV BLOC, NITISH MAY NOW STIR UP OBC POLITICS ACROSS INDIA WITH BIHAR'S CASTE CENSUS

It perhaps sensed the threat a little too late in the day. The state of play must have become clear at least by August 7, when JD(U) president Rajiv Ranjan Singh held a press conference where he minced no words. He spoke openly about two hostile acts against the JD(U) by its alliance partner. One dated back to the November 2020 assembly election, and related to how LJP leader Chirag Paswan was used as a vote-cutter by the BJP. The other was mint-fresh: the threat from R.C.P. Singh, former JD(U) president who had joined the Union cabinet against Nitish's wishes in July 2021, and quit the party on August 6, calling it a "sinking ship" (see *Why Nitish Quit the NDA*). The BJP had been bullish till that point. Only a week before, it had organised a high-profile national executive of its frontal organisations in Patna. Both Amit Shah and party chief J.P. Nadda were there; the latter even made a strong remark against 'regional parties' that stuck in the craw of JD(U) leaders. That frantic attempts at a détente followed soon after Rajiv Ranjan's presser only underlined how ill-prepared it was for this eventuality. Either its political antennae had become rusted, or it was hubris. Anyway, what followed was a shock.

No inkling of it was visible on Nitish's face during that brief pow-wow before the janata durbar even though, uncharacteristically, he kept up an unsmiling visage as he responded to the BJP minister. He only shared his pain about RCP's "betrayal", says a top source. Not a word emanated from him against the BJP. But he had